fidayeen attacks were staged against police, paramilitary and army camps, and government installations. Twenty-nine took place in 2001 alone, making that year the pinnacle of what Sumantra Bose termed the fidayeen stage of the insurgency. Indian military sources attributed the majority of them to Lashkar, which was the premier jihadi outfit fighting in Indian-administered Kashmir by this point.[89]

As Lashkar and other jihadi groups increased the tempo of the war, Islamabad again began talking about peace. On 25 March 2000 President Clinton visited India and Pakistan. Though his visit to Pakistan amounted to nothing more than a brief stop after a considerably longer time spent in India, he argued vociferously for a halt to state-sponsored militancy. After his visit, India and Pakistan initiated an 'informal, unannounced peace process.' Several months later, during a visit by US Under Secretary of State Thomas Pickering to Islamabad, Musharraf agreed to a unilateral ceasefire, bringing a halt to Pakistani artillery firing along the LoC. This practice had provided a shield to militants infiltrating into Indian-administered Kashmir, and once artillery fire ceased casualties among those trying to breach the LoC rose.[90]

However, the pace of the conflict did not abate. Rather than instructing its proxies to halt their activities, the ISI directed them to stop claiming responsibility for attacks in Indian-administered Kashmir. It also appealed to HM to honor the ceasefire on a short-term basis.[91] While HM was divided over negotiations with India, Lashkar wanted no part of peace. In an attempt to derail the process, the group launched its most brazen fidayeen attack yet. On the night of 22 December 2000 two Lashkar militants entered the historic Red Fort in Delhi, which at the time was being used as an army garrison, and killed two Indian soldiers and a guard before escaping. The low body count belies the large-scale significance of the attack. This was the first fidayeen assault conducted beyond the borders of Indian-administered Kashmir and took place in the heart of India's capital, illustrating Lashkar's reach and capabilities. After the attack, a Lashkar spokesman said, 'By attacking the Red Fort, we want to stress that India should stop this drama of cease-fire and talks; it should pull out its forces from Kashmir.'[92] New Delhi showed restraint and the ceasefire continued. Less than a month later, six Lashkar militants stormed Srinagar airport in a second audacious attack. All six militants were killed, as were four Indian